Deluge: Starting Lore

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The Deluge experiment begins one thousand years after a war that drowned the world, when strangers from the old world come to teach five scattered peoples, then leave them to make their own history.

The catastrophe

A global nuclear war ended the old world. Its heat melted ice caps as vast as those that covered the Earth at the start of the Younger Dryas, and the meltwater rose over the land in a great deluge.

Coastal plains, land bridges and the low valleys where most people had lived went under. The cities, the industry and the people who knew how to run them were gone. A thousand years later, almost nothing of that world survives except what a few people carried away from it.

The flood has not finished. At year 0 the sea still stands about 60 m below its final level, and over the next three thousand years it keeps rising in surges, drowning coastlines that the survivors' descendants will have settled. The climate is still unstable too: a long cold snap lasts the first twelve centuries before the world warms.

The world at year 0

One thousand years after the war, the survivors' descendants live as five peoples of hunter-gatherers, each a cluster of bands of 100 to 250 people in its own home region.

They forage, hunt and move with the seasons. They don't farm, build permanent settlements or keep any record of the old world. Whatever they remember of it is whatever survived a thousand years of retelling.

The five peoples are not designed. Each starts with a random temperament: how hierarchical, warlike, open to strangers, ritual-minded or mobile it is, and a random way of making decisions.

A thousand years of separation have also made them look and sound different. Each people has its own appearance, in skin tone, hair, eyes and stature, and its own way of speaking. None of these differences makes one people stronger, smarter or more fertile than another. They are simply visible, and audible, to anyone who meets them.

The peoples are known only by letters, A to E. Their names, customs and stories are left for the experiment to produce.

The teachers

At year 0, a group of 30 to 60 people arrives among the five peoples by air. They are human, not visitors from another world: they carry the knowledge and technology of the world before the catastrophe, more advanced than anything we have today. Where they kept it for a thousand years is never explained. They look unlike any of the five peoples.

What they bring

- Aircraft, which let them travel between the five peoples and later leave.
- Weapons. They use them only if attacked, and no attack on them succeeds.
- Tools and medicine.
- The knowledge of civilization: farming, food storage, permanent building, division of labor, megalithic construction, and watching the sky to keep a calendar.

What they do

Over about fifty years they visit the five peoples and live among them for a time, teaching. Each people learns at its own pace. Some are more open to strangers than others, and the teachers stay longer with some than others, so no two peoples come away with the same knowledge.

When they leave a people, there is about a one-in-three chance they leave some of their artifacts behind: a few tools, medicines or weapons that work like nothing else in the world. These can't be copied or repaired, and over the following decades or centuries they wear out one by one.

How they leave

When their time is done, the teachers depart by air and never return. They don't found a nation, rule anyone or fight for land. Everything they leave behind is in the hands of the five peoples: the knowledge, the artifacts, and the memory of having seen them.

The next 11,000 years

From the teachers' departure on, nothing is written in advance. The five peoples face the rising sea, droughts and cold years, and each other, for the next eleven thousand years.

They may farm or go back to foraging, settle the river valleys or move on, build monuments, split into rival peoples, merge, conquer or be conquered. Knowledge can spread, or be lost when a people collapses. Some peoples may disappear entirely. As they meet, trade, intermarry and fight, their looks and speech blend or stay apart, and how much those differences come to matter to them is theirs to decide.

They will also remember. What they keep of the flood, the arrival of the teachers, their first harvests, their wars and their founders is passed down and reshaped with every generation. Whatever founding stories they end up with are their own work.

At year 11,000 the experiment asks where each of the five peoples stands, what became of the teachers' gift, how the peoples see one another, and what each people believes about where it came from.